

Don't Just Work Hard, Work Smart: Balance Smart, Featuring Sue Nokes

Sue Nokes, Advisory Board Vice Chairman, Asurion; Former Chief Customer & Operations Officer, T-Mobile

Pat said, "The greatest strength any human being can have is to recognize his or her own weaknesses." Pat surrounded herself with assistant coaches that complemented her style and understood her weaknesses. She practiced balance by leaning on others through the intentional delegation of responsibilities.

Here are three ways Pat brought balance to strength and weaknesses in her organization.

First, solicit feedback from your peers. It's hard for employees to be completely honest with the boss. The best and oftentimes most critical feedback will come from leaders in your organization or on your team, namely your peers. They can be your greatest asset for checking emotional blind spots and gaining self-knowledge. Why? Your peers see a different side of you than most people. Pat regularly solicited feedback from other coaching leaders such as John Wooden, Bruce Pearl, Coach K (Mike Krzyzewski), and Phillip Fulmer, to name a few, for her personal growth and development.

Second, prioritize problems. All problems are not created equal. Learn to prioritize both long-term and short-term opportunities and which one will be accomplished over time. Choose your battles. Know when to compromise and save your energy for those problems that most threaten your values and goals. You can't fix everything at once. Over the course of her career, Pat persistently chipped away the obstacles and seized each opportunity to achieve the long-term goal of advancing women's basketball. She also made short-term adjustments at halftime to win a game.

Third, lead through influence and example -- and there was no better example of integrity and hard work than my friend, Pat Summitt. A great leader wants their team to follow them, but out of commitment to the goals and what you're trying to achieve together, not out of compliance and fear. Leadership is an art, not a science. To gain commitment, good leaders identify and communicate a foundational system of values that runs through everything they do. When the values and goals are transparent, your team is more likely to trust your leadership and take the risks you ask of them.

Coach Pat Summitt

"Working smart is about understanding what you are best at and what you are worst at and what you will settle for in the interest of progress. It's about arriving at a balance."